

“Asia experienced a temporary gain from the discovery of America, but Africa suffered. America had all the silver and gold Europe needed, and this destroyed the African gold markets and the dependent trade networks. Cities such as Timbuktu and the Songhai Empire of which it was a part crumbled as merchants abandoned the ancient trade routes.

To replace the Mediterranean trade of cloth, beads, leather, and metals upon which the Africans had become dependent, the Africans now had only one commodity that the Europeans wanted—slaves. For centuries the African merchants had sold a small but steady number of slaves to the Middle East, but with the decline of their traditional European trade and with the opening of America, the slave trade became a boom. The Africans thus became victims of the discovery of America as surely as did the American Indians.”

Source: Jack Weatherford, United States anthropologist, academic book, 1988

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1. Respond to parts A, B, and C.

- A. Identify one claim that the author makes in the first paragraph about the effect of the discovery of the Americas on Africa.
- B. Describe one economic change in the Americas that occurred as a result of the developments discussed in the second paragraph.
- C. Explain one reason why “American Indians” “became victims of the discovery of America” as suggested by the author in the last sentence of the passage.